

The Bombay, Baroda and Central India (BB&CI) Railway – connecting Bombay to Baroda with lines to Surat and Ahmedabad – opened to the public by 1865. They faced several challenges, including heavy flooding of the River Narmada, which washed away the construction twice and forced the engineers to go back to the drawing board and come up with a new plan.

Construction in north India to connect Sind with Delhi began under four separate undertakings. While the Scinde Railway built the 173-km Karachi–Kotri line in 1861, the Punjab Railway constructed the 408-km Multan–Amritsar line that opened in 1861. The Indus Steam Flotilla company connected the two lines via a steamer that operated between Kotri and Multan, until it was brought together under the Scinde, Punjab and Delhi Railway (SPDR) in 1869.

The Eastern Bengal Railway, formed in 1858, built two lines – from Calcutta to Kushtia via Barrackpore, and another that branched off to Dacca via a junction near Calcutta. In 1862, subsidies were also granted to the Indian Branch Railway Company and the Indian Tramway Company. The former was to build feeder branches in north India, while the latter focused on areas around Madras.

By the end of 1868, 6,400 km of track were in operation, and another 3,200 km were under survey or construction. It was only a matter of time before the entire country was connected, and, eventually, unified.